Times pointed out the ‘originality and vigor’ of the Indian postal department and observed that:[94]

> The sepoy on active service, the coolie from distant provinces on the Assam tea gardens, and the domestic servant following his master’s fortunes over the length and breadth of India, are as sure that their monthly wages will punctually reach their remote homes as if they paid over the money with their own hands.

Postal money order traffic grew so much that it amounted to 2–3 per cent of the Gross Domestic Product (GDP) between 1900 and the 1960s. In the Bombay of the 1930s, ‘the practice of sending money orders had proved to be so disruptive’ due to breaks taken from work that the Bombay Mill Owners Association approached the postal authorities to arrange for remittance services directly from the mill premises.[95] International postal money orders would pour in from overseas Indian emigrants who also had the option to remit through facilities provided by the protector of emigrants. Postal money orders gradually lost out to bank transfers and private money transfer operators in the last quarter of the 20th century and rapidly lost market share in the past decade.

Between 1880 and 2010, the post offices of India issued 7 billion postal money orders and formed the financial lynchpin of the Great Indian Migration Wave. The word ‘money order’ became an adjective as recipient regions were labelled as money order economies. Money orders supported the migrants’ families and enabled them to stay away from home for longer periods. The trust in the postal service was supreme. I recollect a money order sent to my mother reaching my grandmother in a neighbouring house, only because the postman thought it wise to do so in my mother’s absence!

The Wave Continues

It would be difficult to write the history of Europe in the late 19th century without acknowledging the significance of the ‘Age of Mass Migration’ between Europe and the rest of the world. Similarly, it would be hard to omit the ‘Great Migration’ of African–Americans within the US in its 20th